

DOWN TO THE WIRE

With no party sure of getting an absolute majority, recent history is likely to repeat itself and the post-poll scenario may witness the emergence of another coalition—and more political instability

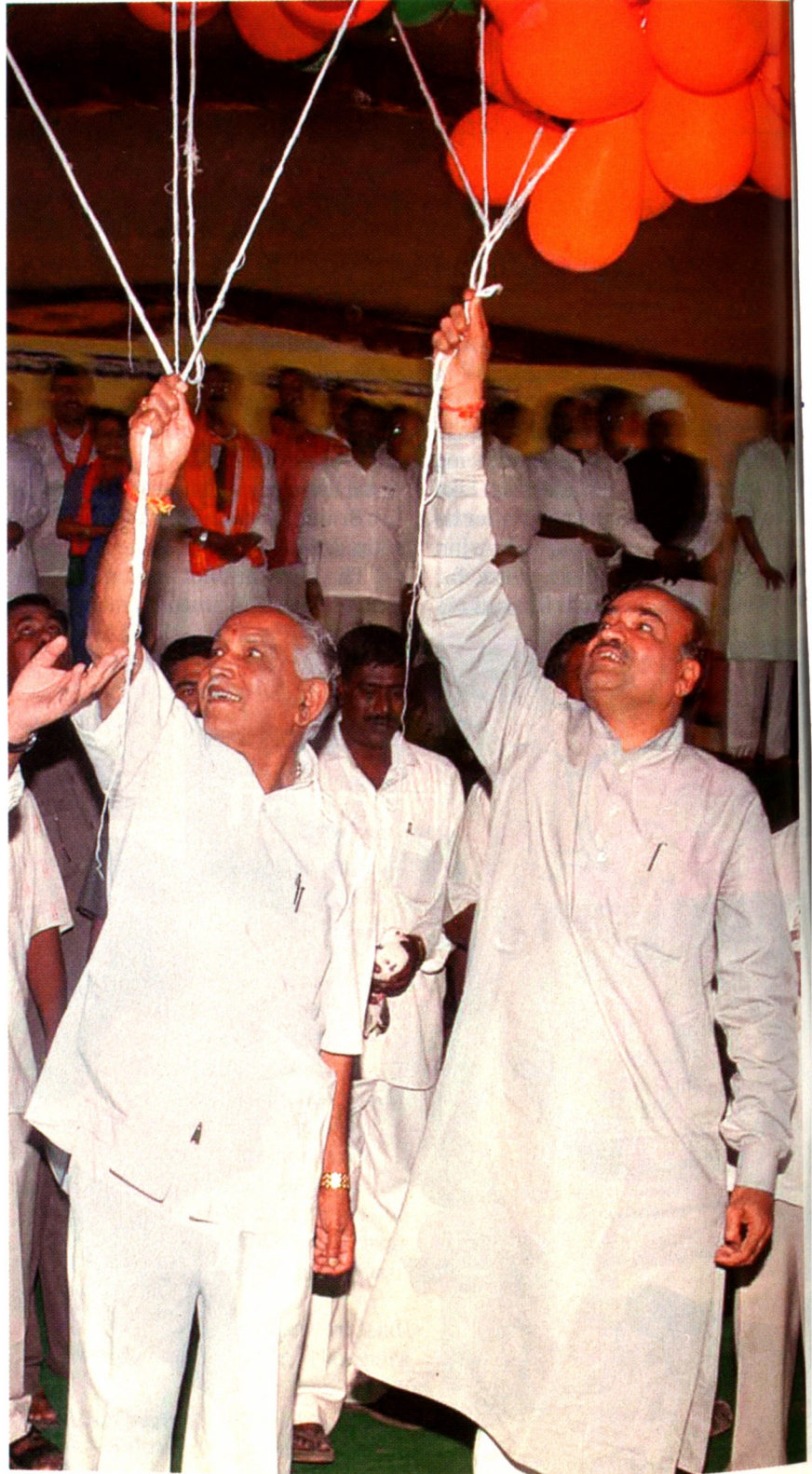
Photograph by KPN

■ **By Stephen David**

As the April 23 deadline for filing nominations for the first phase of the three-phase Assembly polls next month passed, the three major contenders—Congress, BJP and JD(S) of former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda—were plagued by the all-too familiar problems: dissidence and internal discord over the final list of candidates. Outside their party headquarters, supporters of those denied tickets took out their anger on the leaders. The frustration levels were particularly high in the Congress, which was faced with a revolt-like situation and was even forced to shut down its office in Bangalore last weekend.

After the Congress announced its first list on April 19, disappointed aspirants became easy targets for poaching by BJP. With no party sure of getting an absolute majority, the election results may well be a repeat of the last one which threw up a hung Assembly. Following a dishonourable breakup with BJP by Deve Gowda's son and former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy—who refused to keep the gentleman's agreement and allow B.S. Yeddyurappa of BJP to continue as chief minister for the remainder of the 20 months of their alliance—Yeddyurappa undertook rally after rally across the state where he told massive gatherings of the betrayal at the hands of Deve Gowda and his family.

But several months later, there is no guarantee of that sympathy wave turning the tide in his favour. What BJP has unwittingly become is a parking lot for disgruntled Congress politicians. Says state BJP President and Vokkaliga leader D.V. Sadananda Gowda, "Our doors are wide open for anyone to join



FLYING HIGH: BJP leaders Ananth Kumar (right) and Yeddyurappa hope that the sympathy factor for the party is not just hot air